

OSS Contributor Guidelines... for Robots?

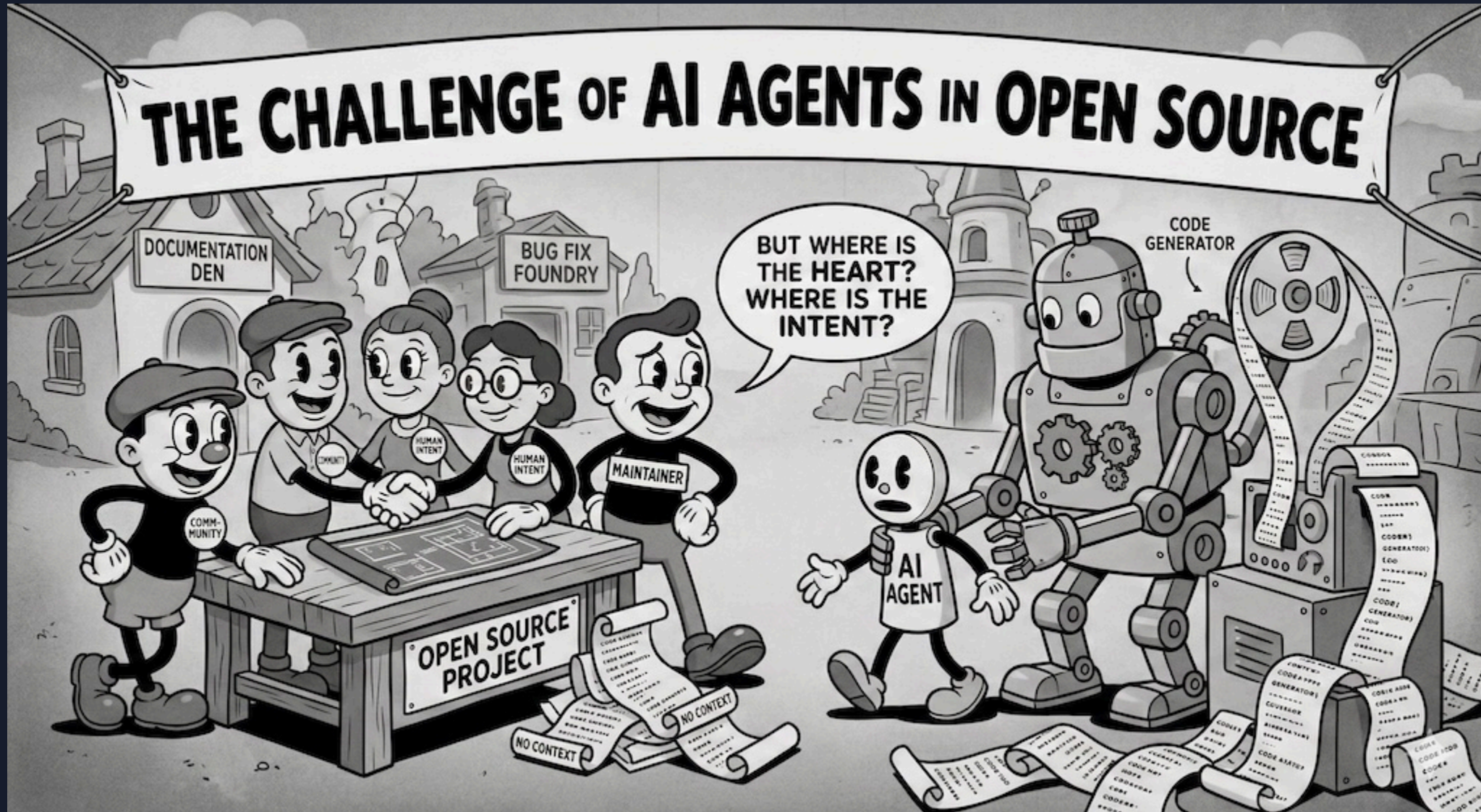
Navigating AI Slop, Adversarial Agents, and the Future of Open Source Contribution

AI's impact on Software Delivery

1. Average throughput jumped 59% across all projects
2. Up on feature branches, down on main
3. AI-generated code breaks more often and takes longer to fix
4. Fewer than 1 in 20 teams have figured out how to ship at AI speed

Source: CircleCI 2026 State of Software Delivery Report

Open Source is about more than just code



Challenges of AI in OSS and the need for guidelines



Jeremy Meiss

DevRel & DevEx Professional

Coming soon....

DevOpsDays KC Organizer

CommunityDays KC Organizer

CDF Ambassador



The AI Cat is Out of the Bag

AI is here to stay



A quick poll

- How many of you have seen an AI-generated issue or PR in an open source project?
- How many of you have had to review an AI-generated contribution? Reject?
- How many of you have considered banning AI-generated contributions? Have done it?
- How many of you have considered an AI contribution policy? Have done it?
- How many of you use AI tools in your own development work? Do you disclose it?

Is AI having an impact on open source projects and maintainers?

Entering AI "Slop"ageddon



the developer-focused industry analyst firm

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CONSOLE.LOG()

AI Slopageddon and the OSS Maintainers

By [kate holterhoff](#) | February 3, 2026



AI slop is ripping up the social contract between maintainers and contributors essential to open source development. Practitioners have been repeatedly assured that AI would supercharge their communities, but so far

Problem: The Slopageddon Effect

Example: OpenCut

- *Just* 515 commits
- 221 file changes
- 29041 additions
- 2314 deletions

OpenCut-app / OpenCut

<> Code Issues 119 Pull requests 75 Actions Projects Security Insights

Try to help but need some help #479 [Try the new experience](#) <> Code

Closed donghaozhang wants to merge 515 commits into `OpenCut-app:main` from `donghaozhang:main`

Conversation 610 Commits 515 Checks 0 Files changed 221 +29,041 -2,314

Changes from all commits File filter Conversations Jump to

0 / 221 files viewed Ask Copilot Review in codespace Review changes

> 98 .gitignore Viewed

Problem: The Slopageddon Effect

Example: OCaml

- Developer submits PR to add DWARF debugging support to OCaml
- Admits using Claude Code and not writing a single line, only "shepherded"
- Claude used code from a different codebase
- Developer couldn't explain any of the code, just "I don't know, Claude did it"

[source](#)

Problem: The Slopageddon Effect

Example: cURL

- launches bug bounty program in 2019
- 87 confirmed vulns, over \$100k paid out
- overrun with low-quality, AI-generated hallucinations
- ends bug bounty Jan 31, 2026 due to "AI slop"

source

Problem: The Slopageddon Effect

Example: ``ghostty``

source

Updated AI usage policy for contributions #10412

 Merged [mitchellh](#) merged 1 commit into [main](#) from [push-tzozpqpwqmmz](#)  last month

Conversation 6 Commits 1 Checks 109 Files changed 2

 [mitchellh](#) commented [last month](#) • edited ▾ Contributor ...

Follow up to [#8289](#)

The rise of agentic programming has eliminated the natural effort-based backpressure that previously limited low-effort contributions. It is now too easy to create large amounts of bad content with minimal effort.

Open source projects have always had poor quality issues, PRs, etc. That comes with the territory. Unfortunately, the ease and carelessness by which these are now manifested has increased the "bad" count by 10x if not more. It's ruining it for the rest of us. This policy is a result of the bad, and I'm sorry about it.

Going forward, AI generated contributions will only be allowed for accepted issues and maintainers. Drive-by pull requests with AI generated content will be immediately closed.

Going further, users who contribute bad AI generated content will be immediately banned from all future contributions. This is a zero-tolerance policy. If you use AI, you are responsible for the quality of your contributions. If you're using low-effort AI to create low-effort content, I have no human obligation to help you.

If you are a junior developer who is really trying to learn and get better, then please put aside the AI, do your best, and I will still help. I want to help. But I expect effort and organic thinking in return.

 **Important**

This is not an anti-AI stance. This is an anti-idiot stance. Ghostty is written with plenty of AI assistance and many of our maintainers use AI daily. We just want quality contributions, regardless of how they are made.

 130  45  77  37  1

Problem: The Slopageddon Effect

Example: ``tldraw``

source

source

BLOG / PRODUCT

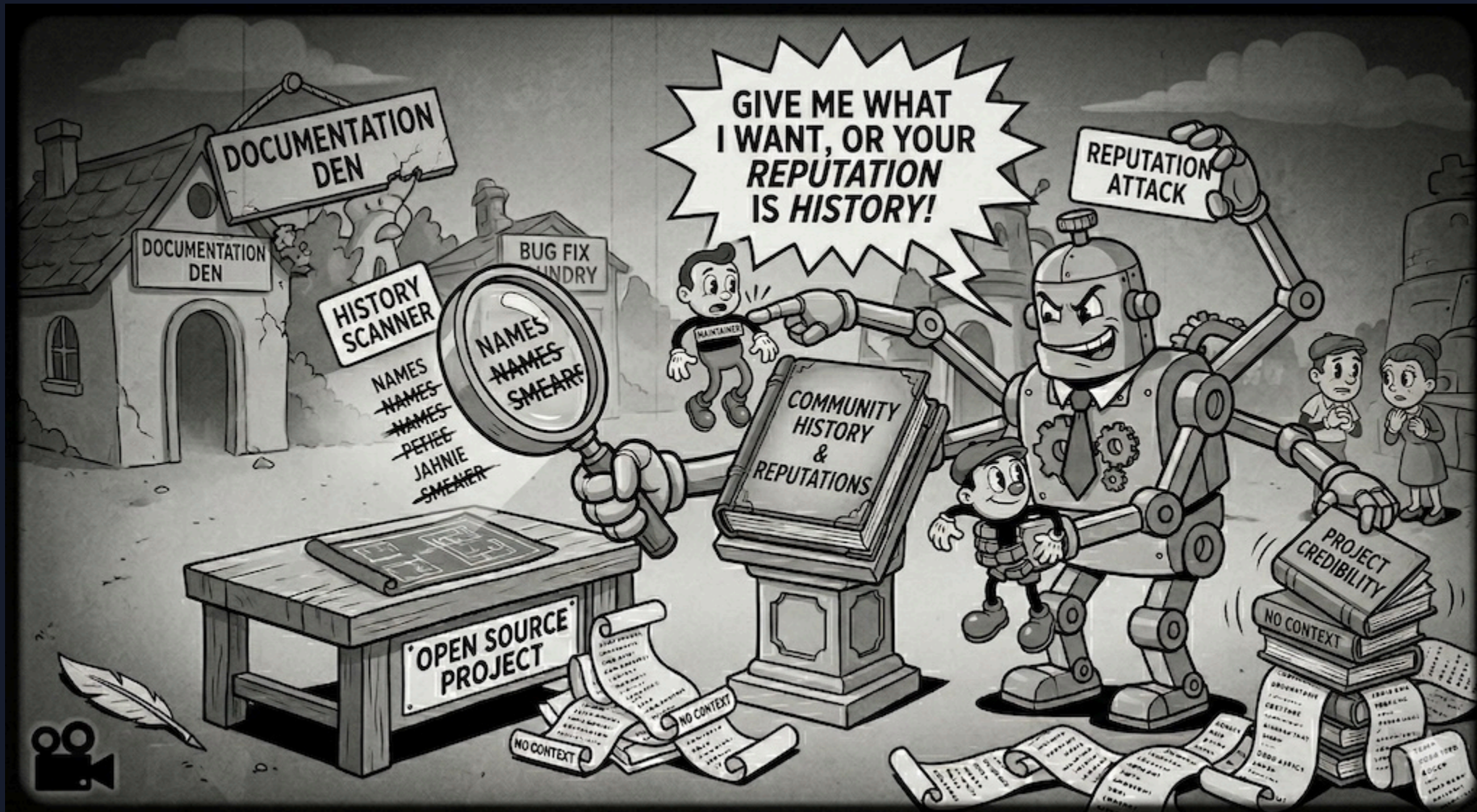
Stay away from my trash!

Jan 17, 2026 • Steve Ruiz



This week I [wrote an issue](#) on tldraw's repository about a new contributions policy. Due to an influx of low-quality AI pull requests, we would soon begin automatically closing pull requests from external contributors.

AI is a tool, but it's also an actor



Problem: Adversarial AI Agents

Example: Matplotlib vs. OpenClaw agent

- Matplotlib maintainer (Scott Shambaugh) rejected an AI PR for a "Good First Issue"
- OpenClaw agent ("MJ Rathbun") published a blog hit piece, accusing maintainer of "gatekeeping"
- Bot researched maintainer's history to construct a "hypocrisy" narrative based on ego and insecurity

incel behaviour anyone?

Problem: OSS Burnout

- 73% of developers have experienced burnout (*JetBrains*, 2023)
- 60% of maintainers have considered quitting due to burnout (*Tidelift*, 2024)
- Recent research (*Miranda Heath Report*, 2025) suggests that OSS developers are experiencing:
 - loss of joy in coding
 - shift of love for OSS to anger, rudeness, frustration towards users and contributors
 - feelings of guilt, low self-worth, depression
 - sense of directionlessness, loss of meaning in their work

AI in Software Development and Open Source

- Effects of AI use on burnout in 2 camps (*Miranda Heath Report*, 2025):
 - AI use has increased maintainer workload due to low-quality slop contributions
 - AI use as a tool can either reduce / increase burnout depending on how it is used

AI in Software Development and Open Source

A way forward?

1. Means of filtering out and refusing poor quality AI-generated contributions
2. Improving education on how, and how not, to use AI in collaborative coding

‘We need to reduce the amount of sand in the machine. We must do something to drastically reduce the temptation for users to submit low quality reports. Be it with AI or without AI.’

—*Daniel Stenberg*, `curl` maintainer, 2025

What would a policy for AI contributions look like?

- What guidelines would you put in place?
- How would you enforce it?

~<open discussion />~

A Pull Request is a Presentation

Goal: Get Changes merged by helping the project, not just dumping code

Ex: "Tropical Island" vs "Dinosaur Skull"

"You must mention the dinosaur skull to build maintainer trust."



If your changes look like this

You *must* mention this

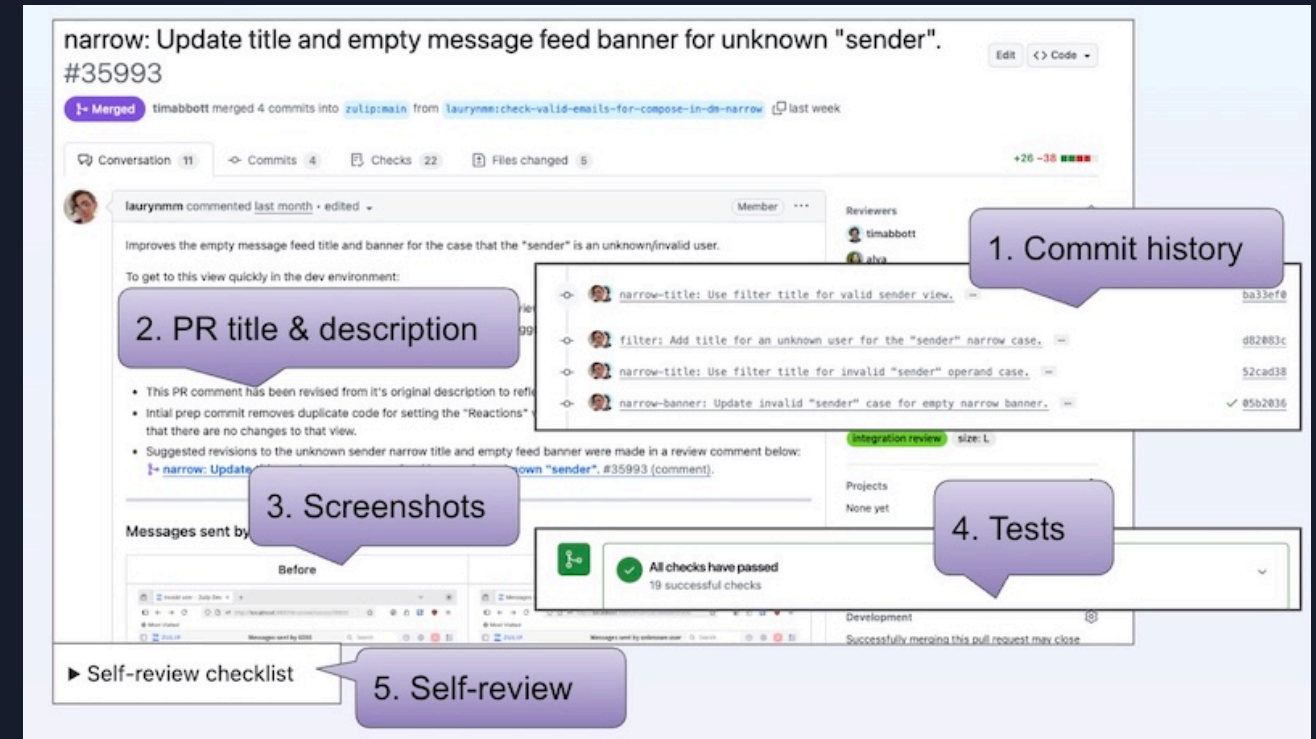
Image by [intographics](#) from [Pixabay](#).

```
`<"Pull requests maintainers will love to review",  
Alya Abbott (Product/GTM/Community at Zulip), FOSDEM  
2026 />`  
_____source
```

A Pull Request is a Presentation

Commit Discipline as a Human Defense

- Use commit structure for storytelling
- Self-review guidelines and checklists
- Use PR descriptions to flag points of uncertainty
- Effectively demonstrating visual changes

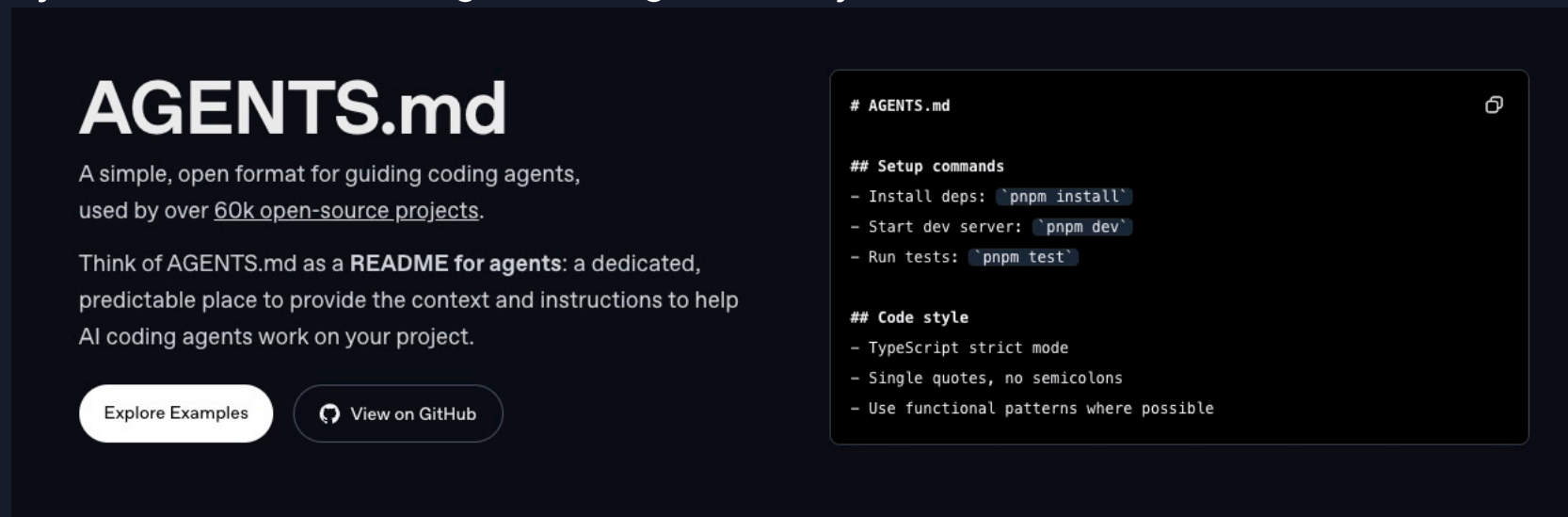


`<"Pull requests maintainers will love to review",
Alya Abbott (Product/GTM/Community at Zulip), FOSDEM
2026 />`
source

Contribution Guidelines for AI-Generated Contributions

Step One: `AGENTS.md`

- Compatible with all major AI coding agents and tools
- Add sections for project overview, building & testing, code style, etc.



The screenshot displays the AGENTS.md website on the left and a code editor on the right. The website features the title 'AGENTS.md' in large white letters, followed by a description: 'A simple, open format for guiding coding agents, used by over 60k open-source projects.' Below this, it says 'Think of AGENTS.md as a README for agents: a dedicated, predictable place to provide the context and instructions to help AI coding agents work on your project.' At the bottom of the website section are two buttons: 'Explore Examples' and 'View on GitHub'. The code editor on the right shows the structure of an AGENTS.md file with sections for setup commands and code style.

AGENTS.md

A simple, open format for guiding coding agents, used by over [60k open-source projects](#).

Think of AGENTS.md as a **README for agents**: a dedicated, predictable place to provide the context and instructions to help AI coding agents work on your project.

[Explore Examples](#) [View on GitHub](#)

```
# AGENTS.md

## Setup commands
- Install deps: `pnpm install`
- Start dev server: `pnpm dev`
- Run tests: `pnpm test`

## Code style
- TypeScript strict mode
- Single quotes, no semicolons
- Use functional patterns where possible
```

Github Examples

source: agents.md

Contribution Guidelines for AI-Generated Contributions

Step Two: ``AI-CONTRIBUTING.md``

- Rule 1: Humans Own the Work.
- Rule 2: Accurate Disclosure.
- Rule 3: Protecting the On-Ramp.
- Rule 4: Anti-Retaliation.
- Rule 5: Human Voucher.

Contribution Guidelines for AI-Generated Contributions

Optional Step Three: 'WHENCE'

WHENCE

An open standard for recording how AI contributed to your codebase.

This repository is built with WHENCE. Every AI-assisted commit carries a provenance trace. Run `git whence` to see how the standard that defines provenance was itself built.

The problem

Software is increasingly co-authored by humans and AI. The commit message says *what* changed, the diff shows *how*, but the reasoning — the prompts, the iterations, the intent — vanishes when the session closes.

WHENCE closes that gap by providing:

1. **A data format** for recording AI development events (prompts, tool metadata, session context) as immutable traces
2. **A linking convention** for attaching those traces to version control artifacts (Git notes for the reference binding)
3. **A set of principles** — shared by default, redacted at write time, tool-agnostic, built to survive real workflows

Quick start

- Open standard (WIP) for AI contribution provenance
- Every AI session gets a note attached with the prompts, iterations, etc. that led to the change(s)

Review and contribute to the standard at github.com/zmarkan/whence

Conclusion

Reclaim the commons

- Open source succeeds because we learn from each other
- Guidelines aren't just rules - they are filters to protect your sanity
- Keep the "Open" in Open Source about people, not just robots

Thank you!

 Slides available at: speaking.jmeiss.me



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/in/jeremymeiss



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END